



Soldiers old and new
Soldiers wait in a town in northern France for transportation to the front in August 1914 *(right)*. By the end of the year many of these regulars had been killed or wounded, to be replaced in 1915–16 by Kitchener's volunteers. By then the nature of war had changed considerably, as is evident from the gas mask holder hanging round the soldier's neck *(far right)*.

Toughened up by route marches and bonded with their comrades, the men's morale was generally high by the time they embarked for France. But apart from being trained in the use of the rifle and bayonet, they were inevitably ill-prepared for the experience of trench warfare.

Ferried across the Channel and then carried by train towards their sector of the front, a fresh division would generally have a long march before it finally reached the trenches. On a number of occasions new arrivals were thrown straight into action. This was the fate of two New Army divisions that reached the front at Loos on 26 September 1915. Having marched for two days along cobbled roads in heavy rain, the men – completely exhausted and with no combat experience – were ordered forward into the fire of German machine-guns. As a result, some 8,000 out of 10,000 soldiers were killed or wounded on their first day at the front. Fortunately, cases of such instant slaughter were rare. If they were fortunate, fresh soldiers would arrive in a quiet sector of the front and have time to learn from experienced troops the secrets of survival in trench warfare.

TRENCH LIFE

Newcomers to the front-line trenches were inevitably horrified by the extraordinary spectacle they presented. Winston Churchill, arriving to serve at the front in November 1915, described the scene in a letter to his wife: "Filth and rubbish everywhere, graves built into the defences … feet and clothing breaking through the soil, water and muck on all sides; and about this scene in the dazzling moonlight troops of enormous rats creep and glide." Yet in this strange world men made themselves at home.



Observing the enemy
Periscopes were essential for observing activity in the German trenches and no man's land. Some were simple metal tubes with a mirror at either end, others were more sophisticated.

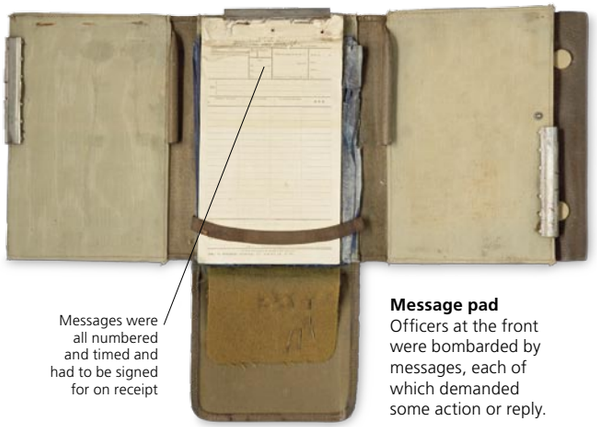
> "CERTAIN PLATOONS OR COMPANIES FOUGHT SHOULDER TO SHOULDER TILL THE LAST MAN DROPPED."
>
> **PRIVATE STEPHEN GRAHAM** ON THE SACRIFICES OF THE BRITISH INFANTRY

The life of a soldier at the Western Front was governed by a daily routine and by the longer-term rhythm of rotation between service in the front line and spells in reserve and at rest. The day in the front line hinged around the fixed points of stand-to at dawn – usually with a tot of rum – and stand-down at dusk. Time was filled with a busy routine of chores, from maintaining and improving the fabric of the trenches to keeping rifles clean and in perfect order, plus special tasks such as observation duties, of obvious importance since the enemy was only a few hundred metres away. Rations were adequate if unexciting. Cigarette smoking was more or less universal. There was a constant struggle against lice infestation and against the rats that thrived among the unburied bodies and discarded food. The soldiers' morale depended in considerable measure upon the physical quality of their trenches, which varied greatly. A good, dry dugout was a godsend. Where the ground became waterlogged, as in Flanders, sodden trenches surrounded by a shell-churned sea of mud made daily life almost unbearable.

The level of danger a soldier faced depended on how active a sector he was in. In some parts of the front an unspoken truce prevailed. In other parts trench mortar fire, shelling, and sniping caused a steady attrition of men. Daily routines such as bringing up rations from the rear became a perilous activity when artillery regularly bombarded the zone behind the front line. Soldiers were inevitably shaken by the sudden death of a comrade, a sniper's bullet opening a hole in his forehead or a mortar shell blowing his body apart. Many preferred active fighting to a monotonous routine in which death was an ever-present possibility. There was rarely any lack of volunteers to take part in night raids on enemy trenches or night patrols in no man's land, even though the percentage of casualties in such small-scale operations was high.

OFFICERS AND MEN

Officers shared the hardships and dangers of the trenches and suffered high casualty rates – 58 British generals were killed in action in World War I, a far higher toll than in World War II. Subalterns – junior officers with the rank of lieutenant or second lieutenant – who led from



Messages were all numbered and timed and had to be signed for on receipt

Message pad
Officers at the front were bombarded by messages, each of which demanded some action or reply.